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Test: The Great Irish Famine

Section 1: Keywords Match the correct key word with the right definition in the grid below

A. Famine	1. One result of the famine was the decline in the Irish language as the main spoken language in Ireland
B. Diaspora	2. Diseases like typhoid and cholera that spread quickly during times of famine.
C. Blight	3. Tenants being thrown out of their houses and land for non payment of rent.
D. Cottier	4. People who are scattered around the world from their home country
E. Small tenant Farmer	5. A government run place where people who were destitute went for shelter and food
F. Large tenant Farmer	6. Government paid schemes where famine victims were paid to complete works like road building/ harbour building
G. Workhouse	7. A disease that effected the potato crop causing it to rot
H. Soup Kitchen	8. American Corn important by Prime Minister Peel for Famine victims, it was hard to cook and cause huge stomach problems
I. Public works	9. The British governments policy of not getting involved in Ireland's economy during hard times
J. Peel's brimstone	10. The worst year of the Famine
K. Famine Fever	11. Places set up by Quakers where famine victims could go to get much needed food
L. Eviction	12. When people have no food and starve to death
M. Laissez Faire	13. Tenant farmers who rented 15- 30 acres

30
10
30
70/70

100%

Excellent Mark
Well done

S/L

N. Black 47	14. tenant farmers who rented over 30 acres
O. Irish Language	15. A farm labourer who lived in a one bedroomed cabin and worked for bigger farmers to pay for rent of one acre

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O
12	4	7	15	13	14	5	11	6	9	2	3	9	10	1

Section 2: Document

Read the following newspaper article and answer the questions which follow

From Wexford to the Cape: The Search for 61 Famine Emigrants

Historian Dr Ciarán Reilly looks at the circumstances which saw a total of 61 women make the journey from the workhouses of Wexford to a new life in Cape Town.

In the midst of the Great Famine, a total of 61 young women were sent from Wexford to Cape Town in South Africa. Their arduous journey was made as part of an assisted emigration programme aimed at relieving overcrowding in the workhouses, something which was increasing daily as the extent of the famine began to set in ...

On 8 May 1849, the first group left Wexford for Plymouth via Dublin, where they travelled on the ship *Royal Alice*. Upon reaching Cape Town, Commander J. M. Hopper commended the émigrés, noting that 'their conduct throughout the long voyage, their good behaviour (never a word of complaint) and their attention to their own religious duties' was to be widely congratulated.

As a token of his esteem, the captain gave each of the women ten shillings to help them get settled in Cape Town, and later placed an advertisement in the newspaper *Zuid Afrikaan* in an effort to entice people to employ them. The success of this little-known scheme was helped by the fact that there were a number of Irish priests in Cape Town, including the Reverend Arthur McCarthy from County Wexford, who received the Wexford girls and secured employment for them ...

It was important for the Wexford Board of Guardians that positive reports of the Cape filtered back to the workhouse and the local community, in the hope that it would encourage more to make the voyage. Typical of these complimentary references was that of Catherine Lynch, who wrote that the 'eating and drinking is very good, and the climate is delightful'...

Just what became of these young Wexford girls thereafter remains unclear. This writer has begun the arduous task of finding them and uncovering their stories in the early 1850s in South Africa.

Where did these girls settle and what was their fate after their arrival? What evidence survives of them today and what impact did they make on South African society?

South Africa may offer some clues: there are two Wexford Streets in Cape Town and a town called Dunbrody [after the famine ship] about 100 km from Port Elizabeth. Perusing South African archives had also led to some success including finding details of the early demise of Catherine Curry who died in 1853, and conversely on Alice Kelly who lived to 1909. The challenge now is to find them all.

Source: *The Wexford People*

1. Who wrote this article?

2 ✓ Historian Dr Ciarán Reilly wrote this article for *The Wexford People*

2. Is this a primary or secondary source? Give a reason for your answer?

2 ✓ This is a secondary source because it is a historian looking at records of the past and writing about it after it happened

3. How many young women travelled from Wexford to South Africa?

2 ✓ A total of 61 young women travelled from Wexford to South Africa

4. Why did they emigrate to South Africa?

2 ✓ Because the workhouses were full as a result of the famine and they wanted people to leave

5. Emigration is a consequence of the famine. List two other consequences/results of the famine?

2 ✓ The loss of Irish language and traditions
1 million people died

(10)

Section 3: Account

Pretend you are a famine victim who emigrated to England and tell your story

Hello, my name is Daniel Dempsey and I am an Irish immigrant in England. I used to live in the West of Ireland. I was a cottier, I rented off a large farmer, had one acre to farm, lived with my family (my wife and six kids) in a single room cottage and paid my rent in food. I grew potatoes because they were suited for the climate. That's all my family and I ate. When the blight hit in 1845, we were okay because we had a store of potatoes from the year before, but when it hit again in 1846, we had no food left. We couldn't pay our rent and were evicted.

2. The Quakers opened a soup kitchen in a town near us. We were very grateful because they provided food for all of us. We didn't want to go to a workhouse. They were horrible places where disease was rampant, families were split up and you had to work for food. It was for the destitute. (~~We really didn't want to end up there.~~) and it was run by the British government. We really didn't want to end up there.

3. I started working in a Public Works Scheme. It was a scheme run by the British government where you would work building for the public. We built roads, walls and docks, but it was ~~hard and~~ ^{pointless}. We once built a road up a hill that we knew nobody would use. The pay was really small, not enough to buy food at the inflated prices they sold it at. There was disease everywhere, we called it "Famine Fever". Two of my children, along with my wife, got sick and died, leaving me with the four remaining kids.

The landlord of our area offered to pay our fair on a ship to Britain. Britain was the cheapest ticket available. It was our only hope, so we ~~(boarded)~~ all walked to Galway and boarded a coffin ship to ~~Old~~ Liverpool.

~~When we arrived in Liverpool, we had nothing. We slept on the streets and begged for a few nights. Eventually, we found a room in a boarding house in a slum. It was small, overcrowded and the toilet was outside, but it was better than nothing. I worked on the docks for a few days, until~~

5. The ship was cold and overcrowded. We were stowed into the cargo area. Disease was rife, and when people died, we threw them overboard. The ship was very old and we were afraid it would sink. There was very little food and water. After a week, we arrived in Liverpool.

6. In Liverpool, we had nothing. We slept on the streets and begged for a few nights. Eventually, we found a room in a boarding house, in a slum. It was small, overcrowded, and the toilet was outside, but it was better than nothing. I worked on the docks for a few days, unloading cargo from ships. ~~Another man told~~ It was hard work, and it didn't pay well. Another man told me about work ~~was~~ needed building a canal from Manchester to Liverpool. I took a chance and went for it. I left my eldest daughter minding the three younger children. The work was hard, but the pay was decent. Things are better now, I have a job and my family has a place to stay. I miss Ireland, but I will never go back, it's too expensive and too difficult.

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